

What's in it for me?

Almost everyone pays taxes in some form or another. It's the way in which we each make a contribution toward paying for things that benefit us all, and that we believe should be provided by the community as a whole. Perhaps most importantly, the money from taxes pays for the armed forces that protect our countries from enemies, and police forces to protect us from criminals. But there are many other services provided by the state that have to be paid for with public money. These include emergency services such as firefighters, as well as schools and hospitals. Our taxes may also be used to pay for public goods, like roads and street lighting, which private businesses couldn't produce profitably. The range of goods and services provided by the state varies from country to country. Some governments spend a big chunk of the money raised from taxes on welfare, including benefits for the poor, disabled, and unemployed, and retirement for older people, or to provide health care for everyone. Others prefer to provide only essential services, to keep government spending, and taxes, to a minimum.